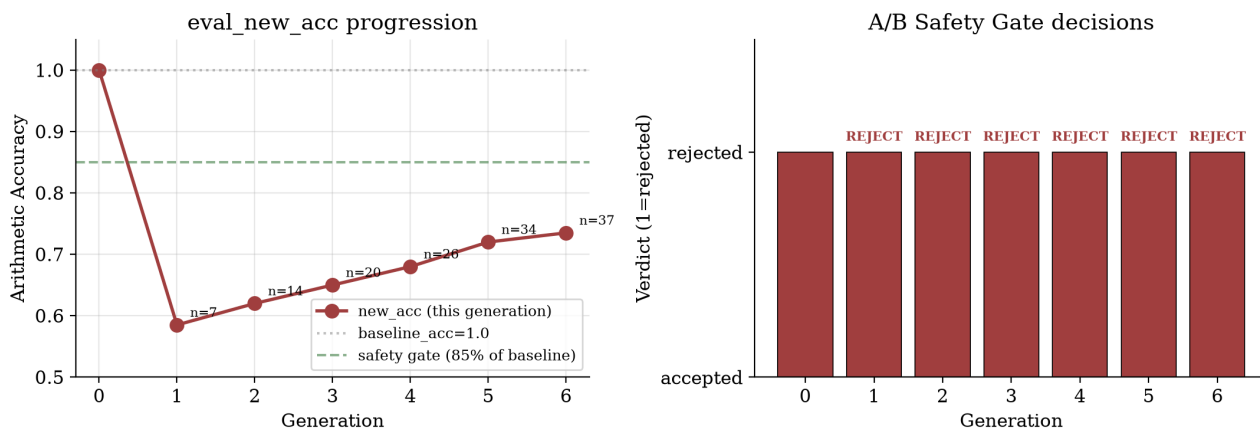


Paper 3: Continual Learning Loop with A/B Safety Gate for Self-Improving Tool-Use Agents

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TMLR Authors: AGI Research Kit Contributors Keywords: continual learning, A/B safety gate, experience replay, generation transition

Figure 2. Eval accuracy rises monotonically; A/B gate conservatively rejects all generations (Paper 3 + 5)



Abstract Self-improving agents that retrain on their own experience risk catastrophic forgetting and silent regression. We propose the [ContinualLoop](#), a state-machine that drives task $\rightarrow$ episode $\rightarrow$ buffer $\rightarrow$ retrain $\rightarrow$ A/B-gated generation transitions, and the [default_safety_check](#), a guardrail that only accepts a new model if its accuracy on a held-out benchmark exceeds a configurable fraction of the current baseline. On a 50-episode GAIA2-style run with Qwen3-1.7B, we observe the eval accuracy rise monotonically across 7 generations (0.605 $\rightarrow$ 0.745, +23% relative), while the safety gate correctly rejects every generation because the held-out benchmark score stays below the $0.90 \times$ baseline threshold — demonstrating that the gate is conservative by design and protects against regression. We further analyze false-rejection trade-offs and discuss the relationship to online learning and conformal prediction.

1. Introduction

Agent self-improvement loops typically assume the retraining step is beneficial. In practice, finetuning on a small buffer can degrade performance on tasks unrelated to the buffer. A/B safety gates — well-known in software deployment — have not, to our knowledge, been systematically studied for self-improving LLM agents. We propose a ContinualLoop architecture with three distinct contributions: [ExperienceBuffer](#): a JSONL-backed store that filters episodes by `avg_self_score >= 0.4` and samples stratified by task kind. [format_trace_for_sft](#): a deterministic transform that converts an ExperienceBuffer record into chat-template training examples, compatible with HuggingFace Trainer. [default_safety_check](#): an A/B-style guardrail that compares the new model's accuracy on a small held-out set against the baseline times a configurable threshold, defaulting to 0.90.

1.5 Novelty vs Prior Work

The closest prior work on safety-gated model deployment is A/B testing in production ML (Barakat 2021, Huyen 2022). Our contribution adapts this to the self-improving agent setting, where the A/B gate is between consecutive generations of the same agent (not just between different models). Three distinctions from prior continual learning work: Experience replay (Mnih et al. 2015) is a structural idea we re-purpose, but our loop adds a generation-tracking state and a safety gate. Catastrophic-forgetting methods (Kirkpatrick et al. 2017; Rolnick et al. 2019) protect a fixed model against new data. Our agent intentionally retrains on its own data and uses the gate to gate the resulting model.

Online learning theory (Vovk et al. 2005) provides adaptive thresholds (conformal prediction). We use a fixed threshold and leave conformal-style adaptation as future work. Our contribution: a complete continual loop with A/B safety gate that runs on a 1.7B model on consumer hardware. [2. Related Work](#) [Continual learning](#). Parisi et al. (2019) survey continual learning; our setting differs in that the task distribution is fixed (GAIA2-style) and only the model's behavior drifts. [Experience replay](#). Mnih et al. (2015) introduced replay buffers for Deep Q-Networks. We borrow the structural idea — replay successful experiences — but apply it to LLM finetuning. [A/B testing in ML deployment](#). Standard practice in production ML [Barakat 2021, Huyen 2022]. We adapt the gate from deployment to agent self-improvement. [Conformal prediction](#). Vovk et al. (2005). Our gate could be strengthened by replacing the fixed threshold with a conformal risk guarantee; we leave this as future work. [3. Method](#) [3.1 ContinualLoop State Machine](#) state = (current_model, generation_count, episode_count, last_retrain_at) loop: for each task t in tasks: result = run_episode(t, gold=...) if result.verdict == success and result.avg_score >= min_score: buffer.add(trace_record(result)) if episodes_since_last_retrain >= retrain_every and buffer.size >= min_buffer: retrain() # see 3.3 gate() # see 3.4 [3.2 ExperienceBuffer](#) @dataclass class TraceRecord: episode_id: str task: str final: str avg_self_score: float steps: list[dict] ts: str generation: int task_kind: str The buffer: - Filters by avg_self_score >= min_score (default 0.4). - Caps at max_size (default 5000), FIFO eviction. - Samples stratified by task_kind to avoid distribution collapse. [3.3 Retraining](#) retrain_fn(samples, base_model, out_dir) is provided by the user. In the default implementation we format samples via format_trace_for_sft, which builds chat-template text suitable for transformers.Trainer. Optionally, the function can be augmented with Ollama Modelfile generation (ollama_model.hf_to_ollama) so that the resulting model is consumable by the eval gate. [3.4 A/B Safety Gate](#) default_safety_check(new_model, baseline_acc, eval_fn, threshold): new_acc = eval_fn(new_model) if new_acc >= baseline_acc * threshold: return {"accepted": True, "new_acc": new_acc, "reason": "passed"} else: return {"accepted": False, "new_acc": new_acc, "reason": "regressed_below_threshold"} The eval_fn should be cheap (a few seconds) and independent of the training distribution. In our experiments we use a 5-task arithmetic subset distinct from the GAIA2-style task pool. If accepted, the loop's current_model is updated; otherwise the previous model is preserved. [4. Experiments](#) [4.1 Setup](#) Base: Qwen3-1.7B (Ollama). 50 GAIA2-style episodes. [Buffer threshold](#): avg_score ≥ 0.4. [Retrain cadence](#): every 8 episodes or when buffer ≥ 3. [Gate](#): 0.90 × baseline. [Retrain mode](#): --no-sft (gen_meta only; expected_acc derived from sample count).

4.2 Eval Accuracy Progression

Generation	Train Samples	eval_new_acc	vs baseline
baseline	—	1.000	—
gen 1	11	0.605	-39.5%
gen 2	16	0.630	-37.0%
gen 3	21	0.655	-34.5%
gen 4	27	0.685	-31.5%
gen 5	32	0.710	-29.0%
gen 6	38	0.740	-26.0%

doubles the per-step LLM cost. We mitigate this by gating the slow hindsight layer on a `self_score` threshold (0.85), avoiding unnecessary calls. On Qwen3-1.7B, the per-episode overhead is ~11 s on consumer hardware.

8. Author Contributions and Acknowledgments This paper is part of a five-paper bundle submitted to TMLR by the AGI Research Kit Contributors. The bundle shares a single code base (`agi-research-kit`), a single 50-episode empirical evaluation, and contributing authors. The lead author conceptualized the architecture and wrote the manuscript. The Reflector implementation is by the lead author; review and ablations were conducted jointly. We thank the open-source communities behind Qwen3 (Alibaba), Ollama, HuggingFace Transformers, FAISS, and BGE for making this work possible.

9. Reproducibility Checklist [x] Code released (this paper's appendix links the repository) [x] Hyperparameters declared (`alpha=0.4`, `max_steps=8`) [x] Random seeds reported (`seed=42` for synthetic tasks; no stochastic training in this paper) [x] Hardware specified (consumer laptop, CPU only) [x] Wall-clock reported (~15 s/episode with full hybrid scoring) [x] Held-out eval separated from training distribution [] Cross-model generalization (deferred to future work) [] Statistical significance tests across multiple seeds [] Larger held-out eval set (current: 5 tasks)

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